

to send a man into space with their own space programme. Shenzhou 6 was subsequently launched on October 12, 2005. It carried two Chinese astronauts in the re-entry capsule to orbit around for about five days. The re-entry capsule separated from the orbiter module and parachuted down on Inner Mongolia. The orbiter module continued to do scientific research.

Shenzhou 7 is a Chinese manned satellite that was launched on September 25, 2008. Measuring 2.8 metres in diameter and 9.5 metres high, the craft carried three astronauts for a three day mission in a return capsule. One of the astronauts made a brief spacewalk, mainly to test the new space-suit called Feitian (named after the goddess who could fly). The successful mission and the spacewalk were reported as an imminent precursor to building a space station, Tiangong, in 2010.

Tiangong 1, which means heavenly palace in English, was launched from Jiuquan on September 29, 2011 by a Long March 2F rocket. It weighed approximately 8506 kg and measured 12 metres long with a diameter of 3.3 metres.

Tiangong 1 is the first Chinese space laboratory module launched on a critical test flight to demonstrate the vital docking technology required for a future space station. The new module will be mainly used to carry out the rendezvous and docking test, as well as the mastering of the technologies related to rendezvous and docking and accumulate the experience for the construction, management and operation of a space station. It will be positioned several hundred miles above Earth and is composed of two cylindrical sections with a docking port on its front-end. The two modules are known as the experimental module and the resource module.

The spacecraft is expected to stay in orbit for two years and rendezvous and dock with three different spaceships. At least one of the future launches is to be manned and the taikonaut of that launch will stay on-board for a maximum of two weeks. China's goal is to build a space station by 2020, when the International Space Station is scheduled to retire.

Shenzhou 8 became the next unmanned Chinese spacecraft when it was launched on October 31, 2011. It had a three-week mission, during which time it docked twice with the unmanned space module TianGong 1. This served as a technology test for future space station docking and science experiments, as well as subsequent manned Shenzhou visits to Tiangong 1.

China is rapidly ramping up its space programme and has already successfully sent a lunar probe. It has announced its plans to send a man to the moon by 2025, along with setting up an observatory on the Earth's natural